

When I wrote this paper in February 2025, my understanding of grief and bereavement was primarily academic. I was able to identify developmental differences in how individuals understand and respond to loss, but my knowledge was largely based on textbooks, research, and classroom discussions. At the time, I viewed grief through a theoretical lens and focused heavily on developmental stages, cognitive understanding of death, and interventions that aligned with each age group.

Since then, my perspective has expanded through clinical experience. Working directly with clients has shown me that grief rarely follows a predictable pattern. While developmental theories remain useful, I have learned that each person's grief experience is deeply influenced by factors such as attachment history, family dynamics, culture, spirituality, trauma, and personal meaning-making. I now recognize that two individuals of the same age may experience and express grief in very different ways.

One area of growth reflected in my clinical work is my increased appreciation for the role of emotional presence. When I wrote this paper, I focused primarily on interventions and coping strategies. Now, I understand that providing a safe therapeutic relationship and allowing clients space to experience their emotions is often just as important as any specific technique. I have also become more aware of the importance of assessing for complicated grief, trauma responses, and co-occurring mental health concerns.

Overall, this assignment reminds me of how much I have grown as a counselor-in-training. What was once theoretical knowledge has become practical understanding through direct work with clients experiencing loss, change, and emotional pain.